

1 Talks and posters

The twenty minute conference talk is already specified in `internal/slides/TALK-RULES.md` on the site, distilled from Shewchuk and Peyton Jones, and that file governs. It is not repeated here. This section covers the formats the Presentation page lists and leaves empty: the short talk, the poster, and the reading group.

1.1 What the existing rules fix, so the rest can build on it

Four points from `TALK-RULES.md` carry into every format below, and they are quoted rather than restated.

The purpose: “An advertisement for the paper, not a replacement for it. The goal is that people leave wanting to read it.”

The four questions every deck answers: why the problem is worth solving; what the method accomplishes that no previous method does, *and* what idea makes that possible, with the note that “Most talks answer only the second”; what the evidence is and under what circumstances; and the one idea to take home, “One, not five.”

The shape: “Onion, not clew: state the main message early, then add layers, returning to it. A listener who drifts for a minute should still be able to rejoin.”

The rule on titles: “A title says what the slide argues, not what it contains: ‘Factoring keeps the adversary’s error contained’, not ‘Architecture’.”

1.2 The five minute talk

A five minute talk is not a twenty minute talk delivered faster. The constraint is that only two of the four questions survive at full length.

Inference, mine rather than the sources’. At five minutes, question one and question four are answered in full, question two is compressed to a single sentence naming the idea, and question three shrinks to one number under one condition. Setup, ablations, and limitations move to the backup slides and are reached only if asked.

That yields roughly five slides. The problem and why it matters. The idea, stated once, as a picture. The one result, one claim on the slide. The limit that a listener would otherwise raise as an objection. The one idea again, with where to find the paper.

Two consequences follow from the onion rule. The main message appears on the second slide at the latest, because there is no time for a listener to wait for it. And the last slide repeats the first, because at five minutes a listener has no other chance to recover the point.

The annotation rule from `TALK-RULES.md` matters more here, not less. Everything the speaker would say goes in the notes, in full sentences. At five minutes the temptation to put the script on the slide is strongest and the cost of doing it is highest.

1.3 The poster

A poster session is a filtering problem before it is a communication problem. A reader walking a hall decides in seconds whether to stop, and a poster that requires reading to make that decision has already failed.

The approach on record for fixing this is Mike Morrison's, published in 2019 as a template on the Open Science Framework with an accompanying video, and adopted widely enough to have its own literature of commentary.

Access note. The description below comes from secondary sources discussing the template rather than from Morrison's own template or video. It is marked as secondary and the primary is named, and a poster built from it should open the template first.

The structure inverts the usual one. The center of the poster carries a single plain-language statement of the main finding, in large type, on a solid background. The traditional sections remain present, in a narrow column at reduced size, so a reader who has stopped can find the method, the results, and the discussion. A code linking to the full work sits below the finding, so the detailed material is one scan away rather than on the board.

The design goal, as the commentary states it, is to maximize the insight a reader takes from a session rather than the information a single poster contains. The mechanism is self-selection: a reader decides in seconds whether the work is relevant, and the ones who stop are the ones worth talking to.

Two things carry over from the talk rules without change. The main finding on the poster is a claim, in the project's own terms, written the way a slide title is written. And nothing is asserted that the folder does not support, with a placeholder marked in the open where a result is not in yet.

1.4 The reading group

The Presentation page names one source for this and it is the right one. Cathy Wu's paper draws on fourteen reading groups across five departments, and it identifies a single technique as the thing that makes the format work.

The technique, quoted in full. "At the start of the meeting, ask/make/force everyone ask 2 questions at the beginning and write them on a white board if possible. At this time, welcome any and all questions. Try to prevent members of the group from jumping in and answering them right away because these questions form an outline for the discussion. Then, use the awkward silence to your benefit, to get more questions asked and put on the board."

Why it works is stated directly, and the reasoning is worth keeping: "With these questions, all the participants now have a stake in the discussion and wants their questions answered. Importantly, this approach communicates to participants that they are allowed to not understand parts of the paper, but that they must read carefully enough to have questions. This is the secret to making reading groups work."

The participation baseline. The paper gives a number worth knowing before judging a session: "In any reading group, you can expect a maximum of 50% to participate actively, 20% to talk sometimes, and 30% to never talk," attributed to ten or more years of reading group experience. Against that baseline the author reports 80 to 90 percent participation using the technique above.

A quiet room is the default, not a failure of the material.

Facilitation rules, quoted. Encourage everyone to talk, with the target that participation rises across a term rather than falls. “Ensure that no particular group member dominates the discussion. This includes you, of course.” Maintain lexical order, going from the beginning of the reading to the end, avoiding arbitrary skipping, while keeping the last part of the discussion free for details or broader subjects. “Awkward silence is an indication to go onto the next question on the board.” Keep a machine available to look up background the group does not have. Invite a professor or research scientist where a discussion would benefit from it.

Opening and closing. The first question “can simply ask for the big picture and summary of the reading material.” The closing one: “A good closing question is what the group thought of the paper. This is also a great way to get feedback on your material selection, topic choice, discussion, etc.”

The facilitator’s own position. “As a facilitator, you should be more familiar with the papers than if you were simply in the group. That said, you don’t need to know everything. Just like everyone else in your group, you should not hesitate to ask any questions you may have.”

Two failures the paper records from experience. A group without a stated goal drifts, and the fix is to say at the start of a meeting what the group should be trying to do and why, with the note that participants “need not reach the goal while reading the paper, but the goal will give the entire discussion a general focus.” And a group where discussion comes from a few students, where the recommendation is to keep pressing everyone to speak while watching for the person speaking too much.

Selecting the reading. Aim for eight to forty pages, on the reasoning that shorter readings do not sustain an hour and a half and longer ones are not read. Choose material accessible to the prerequisites set for the group, with the caution that “It is often easy to forget how much you may know about a subject.” The paper also reproduces Keshav’s three step survey procedure for finding material, which is the same procedure recorded in the reading tip.

1.5 Formats still without a source

The Presentation page lists two more headings with nothing under them, and neither is written here because no source has been read for them.

The job talk. The seminar and the lecture.

Both are on the artifact list rather than filled in with generic advice. The rule from `TALK-RULES.md` applies to this file as much as to a deck: nothing is asserted that the folder does not support.

1.6 Sources

- `internal/slides/TALK-RULES.md`, in the site repository. Read in full. Its own sources are Jonathan Shewchuk, *Giving an Academic Talk*, and Simon Peyton Jones, *How to Give a Great Research Talk*, neither of which was opened for this file.
- Cathy Wu, *How to Lead a Technical Reading Group*, MIT Computer Science and Artificial Intelligence Laboratory. Read in full, text extracted locally from the file at `wucathy.com/assets/pdfs/wu2012how.pdf` after a fetch summary failed to return it. Sections IV to VIII. The participation figures in section

VI are attributed there to Professor Polina Golland, and the white board technique to the same source.

- Mike Morrison, the Better Poster template, 2019, distributed through the Open Science Framework with an accompanying video. **Not retrieved.** The description here is from secondary commentary and should be checked against the template before a poster is built from it.

The five minute structure in the second subsection is an inference from the four questions in `TALK-RULES.md`. No source states it.